

High sales figures

Netbook sales are the silver lining in economic cloud, says research firm iSuppli: while PC shipments dropped 23 per cent, netbook sales went up by 10 per cent in 2008

Convenient savers

Netbooks might just be the ultimate thin clients: go to work, log into a central server and use its resources, come back home, enjoy the web

Feature

With any luck, the Voice of Reason may yet prevail, and someone's going to do the netbook right for a change

There's no way to say this without inviting some ire. Netbooks suck. They're the product of a great idea gone sour – when you buy your netbook, you're settling for the let's-just-get-it-out-quickly product. Netbook makers have taken the most essential features of the desktop and squished them into a much smaller package; the results are... interesting.

Cramped

We've had the considerable displeasure of using Windows on a 7-inch, 800 x 480 screen. We've seen the OK and Cancel buttons of dialog boxes vanish below the taskbar, we've seen word processors give us barely enough space to see a paragraph of text, and we don't like it one bit. Though the experience on bigger screens is less annoying, the fact remains: Windows (and nearly every application for it) was never built for such small screens, and that's not likely to change.

This brings with it a potential future problem too: what happens when these tiny screens become tiny touchscreens? Windows XP's Tablet PC edition is uneventful at best, and while Windows Vista and 7 deal with touchscreens better, you'll still have to drag around the little on-screen mouse to use most features, because Windows isn't finger-friendly either.

And you Linux fans sitting in the back there: stop sniggering.

Even though netbook manufacturers

have customised their Linux distributions with startup screens that work well for small screens, they're still running the same applications, on the same desktop environments (GNOME, Xfce, or KDE, as the case may be), making their interface enhancements pointless beyond the program launcher. In some cases, Linux desktops are even worse: the massive fonts and buttons make even a 13-inch screen seem insufficient and uncomfortable.

And it isn't just the software that doesn't belong.

Overkill

We're supposed to look at netbooks as minimalist, almost purpose-built devices. They're supposed to let us use the internet, do some basic office work, and maybe watch the occasional movie. Anything they do beyond that is a welcome bonus. And yet, instead of a hardware platform that's built to do a few things really well, netbooks run on a platform that's built to do as many things as possible, as best as it can – x86.

Using the x86 platform on the netbook makes sense—it's what we're exposed to the most, whether we're using Windows or Linux, and more importantly, it powers our favourite applications. As a general-purpose processor, its architecture is built so that it can handle anything that you try to do on your home PC – the web, office work, games, protein folding, and much more. In the interest of general purpose-ness, the x86 platform sacrifices speed to be able to do everything.

But the minimalist netbook doesn't need a can-do-everything processor, it needs a will-do-the-essentials-perfectly processor. Such processors exist in the wild, too:

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